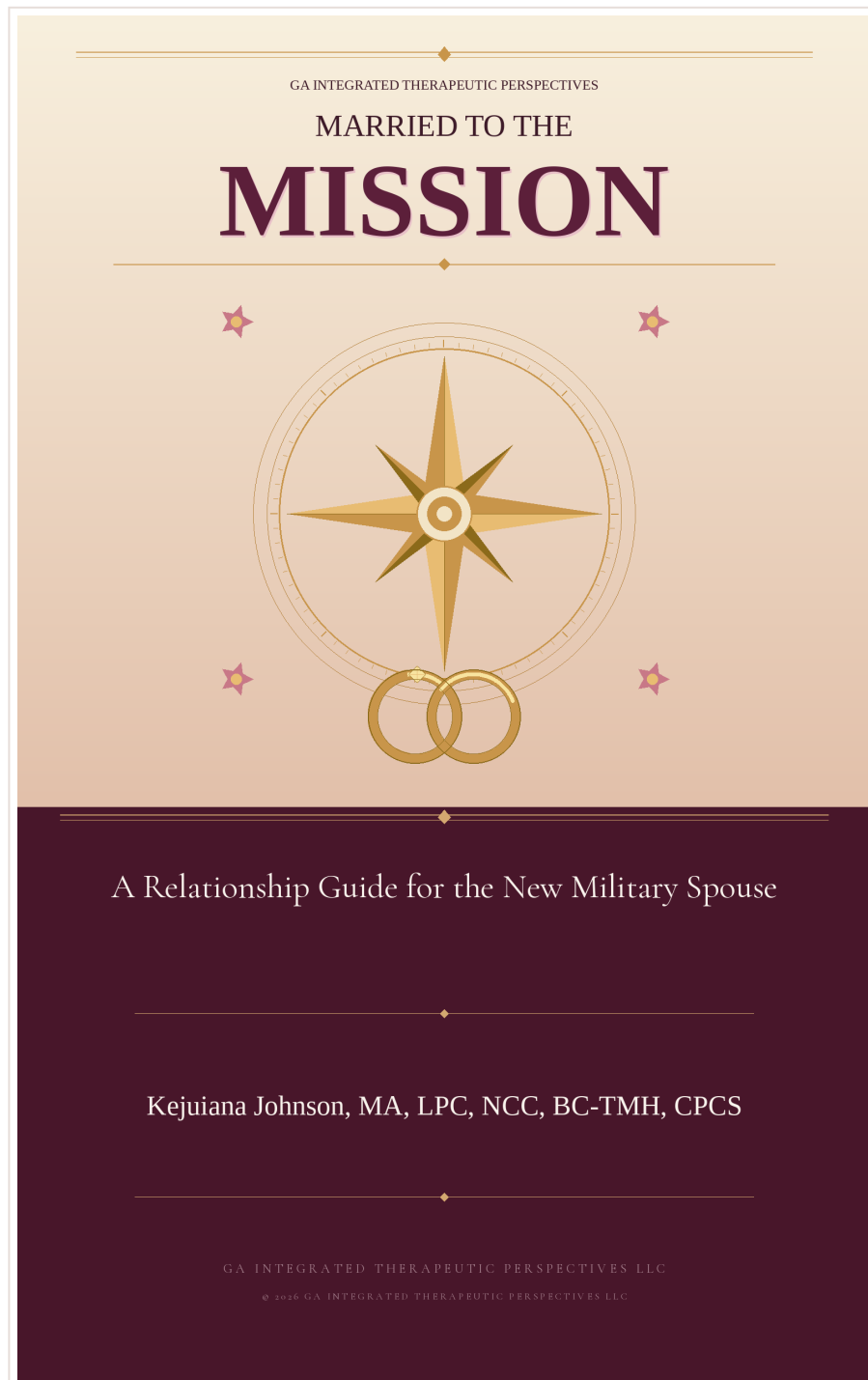


BONUS CONTENT



The Worksheets — Nine worksheets pulled from Married to the Mission: A Relationship Guide for the New Military Spouse.

DO TOGETHER — BEFORE THE WEDDING

The Eight Conversations Checklist

Check each conversation you have had. For any you haven't, schedule a time before the wedding or ceremony. These conversations don't have to be resolved — they have to be started.

☐ The PCS conversation: Am I genuinely willing to follow wherever the military sends us? What does "genuinely willing" mean for me in practice?

☐ The career sacrifice conversation: Whose career takes precedence? Who is responsible for protecting the other partner's professional identity across moves?

☐ The children conversation: Who parents during deployment? What is our plan when the plan falls through?

☐ The financial conversation: Does the civilian partner have independent financial access and identity?

☐ The fidelity and deployment conversation: Have we said our expectations out loud, not just assumed them?

☐ The attachment conversation: Do I know how I respond when I feel emotionally unsafe? Does my partner know?

☐ The identity conversation: Who am I outside of this relationship? How will I protect that person inside military life?

☐ The institution conversation: Can I finish this sentence honestly – "When the military takes precedence over our family, I will feel ____ and I will handle it by ____"?

Isaiah and Zoe checked zero of these boxes. If you've checked fewer than four, make a date – not a fight – to work through the rest before the ceremony.

SERVICE MEMBER — DO BEFORE NEXT PCS

The Briefing Night

Set aside one evening. No phones. Tell your partner: "I want to explain some things about how the military works, because I think it'll help us fight less." Then cover each item below. Your partner marks anything they didn't know — that's where you go deeper.

☐ The chain of command: What I can and cannot say no to, and why

☐ What happens when I ask for something and the answer is no

☐ What promotion means for our family — not just our income, but our time and my availability

☐ What a communication blackout is and what to do when one happens

☐ The people I work closely with — who they are, why our working relationship is close, what that looks like

☐ What I need from you when I come home depleted, and how to tell the difference between depleted and distant

☐ The resources available to our family: OneSource, FAP, chaplain, TRICARE counseling

What Isaiah didn't tell Zoe on the floor of his apartment cost them eight months of avoidable confusion. What you cover tonight is eight months you get to skip.

WEEKLY CHECK-IN — DO TOGETHER

The Depletion Inventory

Once a week, each partner rates their current depletion level and names the primary source. This is not a complaint session — it is a data exchange. Five minutes, no fixing, just information.

My depletion level this week (circle): 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

The primary source of my depletion this week:

What I need from my partner this week to feel supported (be specific):

One thing I can offer my partner this week even though I'm depleted:

The rule: whoever has the higher number gets to name their need first. The other partner listens without fixing. Then switch. This is a data exchange, not a competition.

INDIVIDUAL — AFTER A FIGHT

The Displacement Decoder

Complete this within 24 hours of a recurring fight. Be honest — not about what you said, but about what was underneath it.

What the fight was officially about:

What I was actually feeling underneath the stated issue:

What I needed from my partner that I didn't ask for directly:

The sentence I could have said instead of the fight I started:

Zoe's decoder: "The fight was about dishes. I was actually feeling invisible. I needed him to acknowledge what I gave up to be here. The sentence I could have said: 'I need to feel like my sacrifice matters to you. Can we talk about that?'"

WEEKLY — PROTECT THE WINDOW

The 15-Minute Connection

Schedule one 15-minute conversation per week that is specifically not logistics. Both phones away. One partner asks, the other answers, then switch. Use one of these prompts:

What surprised you this week — not what happened, but what it made you feel?

What did you handle alone this week that you wish I had been there for?

What do you need from me right now that you haven't asked for?

What's one thing you're grateful for about us — not about today, but about us as a couple?

INDIVIDUAL

Know Your Attachment Pattern

Answer honestly. There are no right answers — only useful ones.

When I feel my partner pulling away, I tend to (circle): Pursue harder / Withdraw / Stay calm and wait

What that pursuit or withdrawal looks like in practice:

When I'm activated (scared, hurt, disconnected), what I actually need is:

What I'm most afraid of in this relationship:

My attachment pattern is most likely (circle): Anxious / Avoidant / Secure / Not sure yet

SHARE WITH YOUR PARTNER

Share your answers — especially what you need when activated. Ask your partner to share theirs. You are building a shared map of each other's nervous systems. This map is more useful than any argument you have ever had about the dishes.

AFTER HOMECOMING — TAKE THIS SLOWLY

The Reintegration Roadmap

Complete together within the first two weeks of return. This is not a schedule — it is a shared understanding of what each partner needs to feel safe again.

The returning partner: What I need most in the first two weeks home:

The civilian partner: What I need most in the first two weeks of your return:

**For physical intimacy: I will signal readiness by
_____. My partner will signal readiness by
_____. Neither of us will pressure or pursue before
that signal.**

One thing I want to do together in the first month that isn't about the deployment or the relationship — just about being us:

"I'm not going anywhere" — Isaiah. Six words. This is the entire worksheet in practice. Presence without pressure. Return without demand. Let reintegration move at the pace of the slowest nervous system in the room.

INDIVIDUAL — HONEST ASSESSMENT

Warning Signs Checklist

Check any that apply. Be honest. This is for you, not for your partner to grade you on.

☐ We have the same fight repeatedly without resolution

☐ Six months or more after homecoming, the emotional distance feels as wide as during deployment

☐ I have lost most of my individual identity — friendships, career, interests — to this relationship and this military life

☐ The relationship only feels good between deployments and falls apart during them

☐ One or both of us is getting more emotional intimacy from someone outside the marriage than from each other

☐ I am staying because I'm afraid to leave, not because I want to stay

☐ I feel emotionally or physically unsafe in this relationship

If you checked 1-2: Consider couples counseling proactively — before crisis, not after.

If you checked 3 or more: Seek support now. Military OneSource: 1-800-342-9647. Confidential. Free. Not reported to command.

RESOURCE READINESS

Know Before You Need It

Fill this in now, while things are stable. You want this information before you need it at 11 PM on a hard night.

Our installation's Military OneSource contact / local office:

Our installation's Chaplain office: _____

Our TRICARE plan and mental health coverage:

One couples therapist in our area (trained in EFT or Gottman):

The person I would call at midnight if the relationship was in crisis:
